

Miners Face Big Series With Aggies

University of Texas at El Paso, off to a slow start in its baseball season, picked up some momentum last week and will try to keep it alive Friday and Saturday when the Miners meet New Mexico State University in a four-game series.

A doubleheader is set for 1 p.m. Friday at Las Cruces with the two teams moving to El Paso's Dudley Field Saturday for another 1 p.m. twin bill.

The Miners, with all but one player returning from last year's team, compiled a 3-9 mark through their first dozen games but in the last five contests showed signs of coming around as they won four of those five encounters for a 7-10 record to this point.

The last five games included a three-game series with New Mexico Highlands, last year's NAIA champion, in which the Miners took a 2-1 edge.

New Mexico State has had its troubles also. The Aggies are winless in 10 games.

For New Mexico State, shortstop-pitcher Steve Loe and third baseman Clyde Ziegler are the top hitters.

The Miners have three hitters batting more than .300, led by outfielder Mike Ward at .327. Ward also leads the team in doubles with nine, has two home runs and has hit safely in the last 10 games.

Johnny Miller at .308, Bobby Aguirre .306 and Ron Hix at .302 are the Miners' other .300 hitters. Hix leads the team in RBIs with 14 followed by Charlie West with 11.

Coach Andy Cohen has named lefthander Lynn Hunt and righthander Jess Lujan as starting pitchers for Friday's doubleheader.

Hunt, a junior, has a 3-2 record with a 3.60 earned run average. Lujan has a 1-3 mark with a 5.22 era.

Cohen said Howard MacDonald, a 6-foot-8 basketball player who came out for baseball at the end of the cage season, would start one of the Saturday games.

New Mexico State's first three starters are expected to be Fred Eyhrabide, Curt Montmann and Lee Leonard.